

NASA to give away Shuttles for free
You heard right, once the Space Shuttles have been decommissioned by the North American Space Agency, the space shuttles will be up for grabs for free. Only educational institutions and museums can opt in, and they will have to bear the shipping costs.



Sock and Awe sold out on eBay
Post the incident where a man threw his shoe at President Bush, an industrious developer released Sock and Awe, a flash game that let players lob shoes at the president. Four days, was all the time that it took for the game to be sold out on eBay.



Escape

LOOK MA

YouTube made me famous

The world's most popular video web site, YouTube has given rise to a breed of celebrities in its time. These range from the adolescent antics of lonelygirl15, the understanding answers from Ask a Ninja, and the hilarious foreign language subtitles of Buffalax.

Unwittingly, YouTube has become a fertile ground for criminals, gang members, wannabe terrorists and small time hoaxers grabbing their fifteen minutes of fame. These smart people have taken it into their head to show off their (sometimes imagined) criminal exploits on YouTube, and the result was a bout of YouTube related arrests.

Anton Dunn, under the moniker of The Trashman, posted videos of himself in a black mask claiming to have poisoned several batches of Gerber baby food with cyanide or rat poison. Concerned parents understandably called up the company about the videos. If one video was not enough trouble, he posted another video claiming to lead a bunch of assistants who poisoned many more batches of the food, and that four babies had already died because of his efforts. The wannabe baby killer was exposed as a hoax, the authorities



closed in on him and now he faces 10 years in prison with no access to free video hosting sites.

A bunch of gang-member kids styling themselves as BV Boys posted a video of themselves marking out their turf in the area. On record were gang-signs and concealed weapons. The authorities homed in, confiscated the weapons, arrested the boys, and now their turf is clean.

Ahmed Abdellatif Sherif Mohamed took it into his head to spread a little anarchy with a video tutorial on how to change a remote controlled toy car into a detonator. His intentions were far more sinister, an effort by the international terrorists networks to permeate the web and sow seeds of dissent. The twelve minutes of terrorist propaganda uploaded to the internet cost this young Egyptian student 15 years behind bars in a US prison.

THUBMS DOWN FOR MAC ADDICTS

NY Gov proposes iPod tax

NY Governor, David Peterson does not think that the global economic crisis is a good time for citizens to be entertained. A part of his plans to ease the slowdown is to impose a tax on all electronically delivered entertainment services. This is now widely billed as the iPod tax, which is a misleading name as the tax is not meant only for iPod users.

The law applies a 4per cent tax on everything — e-books downloaded from e-library.net to porn from adultemart.com. Popular services like NetFlix and Amazon will also come under the umbrella of the iPod tax. This is part of a \$121 billion budget covering the next year. Almost anything that is liable to make Gov. Peterson's voters feel good is going to be taxed, in order to ease the credit crunch. This includes TV, beer, wine and cigars. Apart from the iPod tax, or the iTax, there is also the strange obesity tax on sugary soft drinks.

Whatever Happened To... The ICQ

Back in the days when there was only IRC and a few chat rooms as your only means to connect to people, there came ICQ, the first internet-wide instant messenger. The name ICQ is a homophone for the phrase *I seek you*. It quickly captured the imagination of the early netizens and gathered millions of users worldwide, with people showing off their ICQ numbers even on their visiting cards. Yes ICQ had numbers for usernames and the initial six digit ones were most coveted. The universal internet numbers (UIN) were handed out sequentially. Some of the attractive ones were even sold in the free market. The messenger was distinctly unique with some silly features like typewriter noises and online/offline status being indicated by the colour of a flower. In fact, it looked like the messenger was designed by a bunch of hippies.

Soon with the advent of MSN and Yahoo! messengers, people quickly switched to the jazzier options. Besides, ICQ by then was plagued by the scourge of spam.

The messenger was first launched in November 1996. America Online (AOL) acquired Mirabilis, its holding company, on June 8, 1998 for \$407 million. Today, the ICQ protocol can be accessed from any AIM enabled messenger. ICQ still claims to have 32 million active users, but the claim is doubtful. In India at least, its popularity has perceptibly declined. Abroad there might be people logging in, but through other messenger clients and so it appears that the days of the highly vocal, slim ICQ messenger are numbered.

DONT JUST BLAME BAIDU

CCTV focuses on Google and Yahoo!

China Central Television is dispersing the flak it received, for the controversy embroiled Baidu search engine by alleging that Google and Yahoo! sport illegal medical ads on their web sites.

Baidu is the search engine of choice in the world's most populous country, and for a sneaky little reason. The reason being that a shadowy set of constantly changing domain names provide a great service — free and unlicensed music downloads. Despite many takedown attempts, lawsuits and complaints, free music continued to be available on Baidu. Then it came under the scanner for a number of advertisements of medical supplies that were not licenced. This forced Baidu to drop these ads, and the matter would have settled there.

Continuing on its crackdown on illegal medical services being advertised through the web, state-owned CCTV launched a fresh wave of attacks against Google China and Yahoo! China for similar offences. Both the

search giants have been accused of taking money for advertising medical scams.

Google China is however secretly investing in a lot of Chinese internet services. The world's largest demographic cannot be easily ignored by the search giant. Although Google can hardly afford to offer free MP3 downloads, it is heavily investing in online Chinese-run social networking and entertainment services.

WASHING DIRTY LINEN IN PUBLIC

China courts rule against dead woman's friend and blogging site

In other China news, a woman who killed herself and the web service that hosted her blog were ordered to pay Wang Fei \$1,200 in damages. The long and sordid tale reads out like a soap opera, complete with adultery, emotional turmoil and suicide.

It started with Wang Fei going to bed with another woman. His wife, Jian Yan, like any wife was pretty distressed. But unlike other wives, she decided that the best way to soothe her

distress was to blog about her husband's ongoing affair on daqi.com. Helping Jian Yan at this activity was a certain unnamed female friend. The Chinese blogging community was stirred up against the cruel indulgences of Wang Fei, and even the mainstream media caught on. The blog went out of proportion because of all the support, and daqi.com went right ahead and posted photos of Wang Fei with his mistress. What followed was a small scale riot. Wang Fei was fired, his parent's apartment was defaced with lewd language, and Jian Yan decided that enough was enough and committed suicide.

Wang Fei understandably sought justice for the goings-on, and after much deliberation, the Beijing court decided that he was after all, the wronged party. Daqi.com and the late Jian Yan's unnamed female friend were criticised for invading Wang Fei's privacy, and asked to pay \$1,200 as damages.

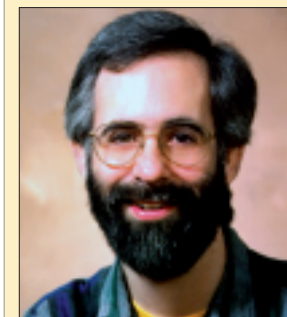
RUSSIAN TRADEMARKS POPULAR EMOTICON

Its not ;-) anymore

Patent and trademark laws around the world are rife with hilarious examples of what people try to own and reap profits out of. After people have

People Who Changed Computing

Daniel Bricklin invented something that has completely changed the business world — the Spreadsheet. In the late 70s, while he was a student at the Harvard Business School, he teamed up with Bob Frankston, to come up



with VisiCalc, the world's first electronic spreadsheet application. Bricklin was watching his university professor create a table of calculation results on a blackboard. When the professor found an error, he had to tediously erase and rewrite a number of sequential entries in the table, triggering Bricklin to think that he could replicate the process on a computer, using the blackboard as the model to view results of underlying formulas. His idea became VisiCalc, for which Bricklin designed the interface and Bob Frankston, wrote most of the code. They released VisiCalc in 1979, an act that fomented the desktop revolution. He also coined the term friend-to-friend networking as recently as 2000. He is now working on wikiCalc, a spreadsheet running on the web.